always boasting of your zeal. Let's take to our swords!' Standing beside Babur Ibrāhīm Beg replied fearlessly, 'What hinders? Come along!'

Babur seemed perturbed. He has written in the *Baburnama*, 'The senseless fellows were for displaying their zeal at a time of such disaster! Ill-timed zeal! That was no time to make a stand or delay!'

Babur called to bring a halt to such stupidity as the enemy was following and unhorsing their men somewhere continually.

Babur Falls Short in Front of Taṃbal's Men

Two miles before Akhsī when they were passing Meadow-dome, Ibrāhīm Beg called out to Babur. Babur turned back to find some members of Shaikh Bāyazīd's flock striking at him. Filled with anguish he turned his bridle, but Bayān-qulī's Khān-qulī suggested against the very step and said, 'This is a bad time for going back.' Babur gazed helplessly, seized his rein, and pushed ahead. Many of Babur's men had been unhorsed till they reached Sang, four miles away from Akhsī. Reaching there, they found no pursuers. Seeing the hopeless scenario, they passed it by and turned straight up its water. Babur had seven other men at his service—Nāṣir Dost, Qāsim Beg's son Qaṃbar-'alī, Bayān-qulī's son Khān-qulī, Mīrzā Qulī Kūkūldāsh, Nāṣir's Shāham, Sayyidī Qarā's 'Abdu'l-qadūs and Khwāja Ḥusainī.

The broad valley was at the turning of the stream. There they found a good little road, far from the beaten track. They made straight up the valley, leaving the stream on the right, reached its waterless part, and around the afternoon prayer time, got out of it to reach the level land.

They looked across the plain—darkness reigned till far away. Babur made his party take cover. Then he went to look out from the higher ground when several men came at a gallop, up the hill behind them. Babur wasn't interested in waiting to find out whether their number was larger. He immediately got his men to mount and ride off.

In reality, they were around a couple of dozen in number compared to Babur's strength of eight. Babur has written, 'If we had known their number at first, we should have made a good stand against them, but we thought they would not be pursuing us unless they had good support behind. A fleeing foe, even if he be many, cannot face a few pursuers, for as the saying is, "Hāī is enough for the beaten ranks".'